SEO & AEO Playbook

The complete process used on a finished client website (local healthcare business, October 2026: health score 54 → 78 / 100 in one month, search score 100 on every page). The code side is already built into this starter; this playbook covers the rest: what to research, what to write, the order of work, how to test, how to report, and the mistakes not to repeat.

Index

#	Section
1	The process at a glance
2	Phase 1: Website audit (method and scoring)
3	The audit checklist (45 checks)
4	Phase 2: Keyword library
5	Phase 3: SEO & AEO growth plan
6	Phase 4: The 10 implementation tasks
7	Writing rules: titles, descriptions, headings, FAQs, photos
8	Structured data map
9	Local SEO and listings
10	Go-live checklist
11	Testing after every deploy
12	Monthly routine and reporting
13	Who does what
14	Lessons learned (do not repeat)
15	Client document rules

1. The process at a glance

Phase	Output (client document)	Typical time
1. Audit the current site (or the design build before launch)	**Website Health Audit** with a score out of 100, issues by section with IDs, action plan by owner (template: `docs/templates/audit-report-template.md`)	1–2 days
2. Keyword research	**Keyword Library** (Markdown/PDF) + keyword CSV (template: `docs/templates/keywords-template.csv`)	1–2 days
3. Growth plan	**SEO & AEO Growth Plan**, client edition: what we fix, gains next month, keyword use, self-check searches, AEO, listings, social, rules, needs from the client, monthly report; appendices with the metadata table	1 day
4. Implementation	10 tasks (section 6), each planned, approved, built, shown before/after	1–2 weeks
5. Go-live and live check	Live verification (`npm run check:seo -- <live>` + testing guide)	½ day
6. Report	**Progress report** with the new score (template: `docs/templates/progress-report-template.md`), **testing guide** for the owner, **brief for the designer**	1 day
7. Monthly	Re-audit, compare scores, AI prompt results, listings, content	½ day / month

Build PDFs from Markdown with `tools/md2pdf.py` (see README).

2. Phase 1: Website audit (method and scoring)

Rule: only report what you verified. Anything you could not check is written "Not verified", with the reason.

Sections, weights and scoring

Section	ID prefix	Weight
Technical SEO	T	30%
Performance	P	25%
UI / UX	U	20%
AEO (AI answer readiness)	A	15%
Security & Health	S	10%

- Each section starts at **100**. Every open issue subtracts: **Critical –15, High –7, Medium –3, Low –1** (floor 0).
- Overall score = Σ (section score × weight), rounded.
- **Partly fixed** issues are re-rated to the size of what is left (say so in the report).
- Status: **Good** ≥ 80 · **Needs attention** 50–79 · **Critical** < 50 **or any open Critical issue** in that section.
- Use the **same method every month** so scores compare. Keep issue IDs stable across reports (T1 stays T1).

Evidence to collect

Check	How
Every page's title, description, canonical, OG, h1, headings, alt, JSON-LD	`npm run check:seo -- <url>` (or view-source)
Lighthouse (Performance, Accessibility, Best Practices, SEO, LCP, CLS, TBT, page weight) on Home, Services, one service page, Contact, phone + desktop	`npx lighthouse <url> --preset=desktop` and without preset for mobile (install outside the repo). Single runs vary: say so.
Redirects: http→https, www→apex (or reverse), no-slash→slash, old domain → new	`curl -sIL <url>`
robots.txt, sitemap.xml, llms.txt, icons, manifest, 404	`curl -sI` each
Security headers	`curl -sI <url>` ; count the 5
SSL expiry, domain expiry	`openssl s_client` , `whois`
Dependency vulnerabilities	`npm audit --omit=dev`
Contact form delivery	Code review + an agreed real test enquiry (never send fake enquiries to the business unannounced)
Google Business Profile, Search Console, Analytics	Needs owner access; otherwise "Not verified"
AI assistants	Ask the AI test prompts; record named/not named, correct/incorrect

Report structure (client edition)

1. Health summary: overall score, section table, Lighthouse table, "at a glance" (how the site is doing · compared with last month · what is working well).
2. Issues by section: ID, issue, what it means (simple), technical detail, pages, priority, effort, status.
3. Page titles & descriptions review.
4. Action plan in one phase, split by owner: SEO owner / designer / business owner (what we do, why, outcome).
5. Needed from the owner.
6. Monthly care routine. Appendix: issues at a glance, items not checked.

3. The audit checklist (45 checks)

The starter already handles the ones marked ✅ by default. Re-check all of them on the real build.

Technical SEO

ID	Check	Default priority if failing	Starter
T1	Canonical, sitemap, robots, OG and structured data all use the official domain; no old domain anywhere	Critical	✅ `SITE_URL`
T2	Sitemap: right domain, slash form matches the site, real lastmod per page	High	✅
T3	Absolute self-referencing canonical on every page	High	✅
T4	Full Open Graph + Twitter with an image on every page	Medium	✅ `pageMetadata()`
T5	One h1 per page, no skipped heading levels	High	✅ (keep it during design)
T6	Every image has meaningful alt	High	✅ (keep it during design)
T7	Google Analytics 4 and Search Console verified	High	Owner access needed
T8	Business structured data complete: logo, image, PostalAddress, geo, hasMap, hours, sameAs	Medium	✅ fields; fill data
T9	favicon.ico, icon, apple-touch-icon, manifest, theme-color	Low	✅ (replace placeholders)
T10	One redirect hop to the final URL; one URL form	Medium	✅ slash form; check www/http in hosting
T11	Live site matches the repo (know which branch the host deploys)	Medium	Confirm in hosting
T12	Titles ≤ 60, descriptions ≤ 155, unique, local keyword	Medium	✅ registry; write them
T13	No thin pages (every indexable page has real content)	Medium	Content
T14	Descriptive link text; named icon links	Low	✅
T15	Local-language version (hreflang) if the audience needs it	Low	Owner decision

AEO

ID	Check	Priority	Starter
A1	`/llms.txt` with business summary, contact, team, services, key pages	Medium	✅ generated
A2	One exact business name everywhere (site, WhatsApp text, GBP, directories)	High	✅ `site.name`

ID	Check	Priority	Starter
A3	Answer-first FAQs on Home, Contact, Team and service pages	High	✅ component; write them
A4	`sameAs` to real profiles; no dead social icons	Medium	✅ renders only real links
A5	Reviews/testimonials real, consented, allowed in the industry	Medium	Owner decision
A6	Opening hours identical in text, structured data and GBP	Medium	✅ one source
A7	No important text only inside images	Low	Design

Performance (designer)

ID	Check	Priority
P1	Photos ≤ 1,600 px, WebP/AVIF, ≤ 200 KB; page weight < 2 MB	Critical if pages > 5 MB
P2	`next/image` everywhere; `priority` only on the LCP image; no preloading of many images	High
P3	Total Blocking Time < 200 ms on phone (few animations on load)	High
P4	Long-term caching for static files and images	Medium
P5	Inner pages light (same rules as Home)	High
P6	Nothing large downloaded on phones when hidden there	Low
P7	No legacy JavaScript for very old browsers	Low

UI / UX (designer)

ID	Check	Priority
U1	Text contrast ≥ 4.5:1 (brand colours on white and white on brand colours)	High
U2	Call / WhatsApp visible without scrolling on phones	High
U3	No blank hero while the main image loads	Medium
U4	Counters and numbers present in the HTML (not "0" until scrolled)	Medium
U5	No dead icons; Privacy Policy and Terms pages exist	Medium
U6	Tap targets ≥ 44×44 px	Medium

ID	Check	Priority
U7	Accessibility: named buttons, iframe titles, pause on autoplay sliders, focus ring, keyboard	Medium
U8	No typos; offers and prices current	Medium
U9	No host badges ("Powered by ...") on the page	Low
U10	Galleries hidden when empty; before/after only where allowed	Low
U11	Map usable (or a clear "open in Maps" link)	Low

Security & health

ID	Check	Priority
S1	Contact form really delivers; success only on `response.ok`; honest failure; spam protection	Critical
S2	Framework and dependencies on patched versions (`npm audit`)	High
S3	Security headers (5) on pages and files	Medium
S4	Old domains redirect (301) to the official domain	High
S5	Code tidy: React keys, README current, no warnings	Low

4. Phase 2: Keyword library

What goes in it

Section	Contents
Brand & people	Business name variants, owner/lead names with credentials
Trust searches	"best/top/trusted in " (target them with helpful content, never with self-claims)
Service-wise	For every service: main term, synonyms, " in ", " cost", " near me"
Location-wise	Main locality + every nearby area, landmarks, pin code, "near "
Search behaviour	near me, open now, open on Sunday, timings, cost, appointment, WhatsApp
Problems and symptoms	What people type before they know the service name

Section	Contents
Local language	Local-language and mixed-script (e.g. Tanglish/Hinglish) queries
Credentials	Qualifications, specialties, roles (exact, confirmed wording)
Procedures/benefits	The words used on service pages
Keyword-to-page map	One main keyword + supporting keywords per page (this drives titles, h1s and copy)
Adjacent searches	Related services the business does not offer yet: confirm before targeting
AEO questions	Questions already answered on the site + new questions to add (FAQ source)
AI test prompts	12–15 prompts to ask AI assistants every month

CSV columns

`keyword, category, intent (informational / commercial / transactional / navigational / local), target_page, priority (P1/P2/P3), notes` (template in `docs/templates/keywords-template.csv`).

How to research (free)

Google autocomplete and "People also ask" (incognito, with location), Google Maps competitors' categories and services, competitor sites' titles, the business's own words (front desk FAQs), Search Console queries once connected. **Search volumes are estimates unless taken from a tool: label them "not verified".**

---

5. Phase 3: SEO & AEO growth plan

Client sections: 1 At a glance · 2 What we will fix (high level) · 3 What you will gain next month and over 2–3 months (with an honest note on timing: changes show in 1–4 weeks, positions in 2–3 months, AI assistants longer; nobody can promise positions) · 4 How the keywords will be used, the **12 keywords we track** and **check-it-yourself searches** · 5 AI assistants (AEO) · 6 Listings · 7 Social media in brief · 8 What we will never publish · 9 What we need from you · 10 What you will receive every month.

Appendices: A **Meta titles & descriptions table** (page, title with character count, description with character count, main keyword: this is the source for `lib/pages.js` and `data/services.js`) · B Full listings list · C Social kit (voice, words, bios, hashtags, weekly rhythm, captions) · D Research and rules · E AEO checklist · F Open items and not verified · G 90-day timeline.

---

6. Phase 4: The 10 implementation tasks

Run them in this order. **Before each task: a plan with the exact visible wording, behind-the-scenes changes, what will not change and the decisions needed; wait for approval. After each task: before/after document, task list with status, then commit and push when asked.**

#	Task	Audit IDs	In this starter	Still to do per project
1	Official web address everywhere: `SITE_URL`, canonicals, sitemap, robots, redirects	T1 T2 T3 T10	✅ built	Set the env var; old-domain 301s in the old host/DNS
2	Titles, descriptions, social previews for every page	T12 T4	✅ helper + registry	Write the text from Appendix A; branded OG image
3	Headings, photo descriptions, keyword placement	T5 T6	✅ outline	Keep it while applying the design; write h1s and alts
4	Business + people structured data; one business name	T8 A2	✅ built	Fill `lib/site.js`, `data/team.js`; validate
5	Answer-first FAQs (Home, Contact, Team, services)	A3	✅ component	Write the FAQs from the AEO list
6	Expand thin pages	T13	—	Content per page
7	Google Analytics 4 + Search Console (+ Bing)	T7	—	Owner access; add GA4 via `@next/third-parties` or a script; verify via DNS TXT
8	Dependencies + security headers	S2 S3	✅ built	`npm audit` monthly
9	Local pages (Areas We Serve) and a helpful guide page	local	✅ Areas page	Areas list; one "how to choose a ..." guide page (helpful, no self-claims)
10	Icons, manifest, llms.txt, link names, tidy-ups	T9 A1 T14 S5	✅ built	Replace placeholder icons

7. Writing rules

Element	Rule	Pattern
Title	≤ 60 characters, unique, main keyword first, brand last	`<Service> in <Area>, <City> | <Brand>` · Home: `<Business type> in <Area>, <City> | <Brand>` · Team: `<Name>, <Credentials> | <Role>, <Area>` · Contact: `Book a <Business type> Appointment in <Area> | <Brand>`
Description	120–155 characters, unique, what + for whom + where + next step; real facts only	" in , for . . Book a visit."
h1	One per page, contains the main keyword naturally	Home h1 can be a short line ("Dental Clinic in Area, City") with the tagline as a paragraph
First paragraph	Answers "what is this and who is it for" in the first sentence	
Location in body copy	**At most once per visible page**	Titles/descriptions may carry it

Element	Rule	Pattern
FAQ answer	First sentence = the answer; 40–60 words; no promises	
Photo alt	Describe the picture, add the topic naturally; decorative → `alt=""`	"Dentist explaining a treatment plan to a patient"
Link text	Says where it goes	"View all services", "Read about root canal treatment"
Never	"best", "top", "No. 1", "leading", "guaranteed", "100% painless", long dashes (—), invented facts, keyword lists	

8. Structured data map

Page	Types	Source
Home	Business (`site.schemaType`), WebSite, FAQPage	`businessSchema()` , `websiteSchema()` , `FAQ`
Contact	Business, BreadcrumbList, FAQPage	
Team	Person per member, BreadcrumbList, FAQPage (if any)	`personSchema()`
Services list, About, Areas, legal pages	BreadcrumbList	`Breadcrumb`
Each service	Service or MedicalProcedure (provider = business ref), BreadcrumbList, FAQPage	`serviceSchema()`

Notes: Google shows FAQ rich results mainly for large health/government sites; the markup still helps AI assistants. Leave out what you cannot back up (no `aggregateRating` without real, displayed reviews; no `priceRange` without real prices). Days "by appointment" are left out of `openingHoursSpecification` and stated in text (`site.hoursNote`).

9. Local SEO and listings

1. **Google Business Profile** (most important): exact name, primary + secondary categories, address pin, hours incl. holidays, phone, website, services, photos, weekly posts, reply to every review. Get **Manager access** for the SEO owner.
2. **Bing Places** (import from GBP) and **Apple Business Connect**.
3. Directories relevant to the industry and country (e.g. Justdial, Sulekha; healthcare: Practo, Lybrate; legal/finance: their professional directories).
4. **NAP consistency:** the same name, address, phone and hours on every listing, character for character.
5. Social profiles with the same name and a link to the site; add their URLs to `site.sameAs` .

10. Go-live checklist

#	Check
1	`NEXT_PUBLIC_SITE_URL` set in hosting; `npm run check:seo -- <live> --strict` → 0 problems, 0 placeholders
2	Real icons, OG image, logo; Privacy and Terms with approved text
3	Contact form: one real test enquiry received; notification email set in Netlify Forms
4	Redirects: http→https, www↔apex to the chosen form, old domain → new (301)
5	5 security headers on pages (`curl -sI`)
6	Lighthouse targets met on the 4 key pages
7	Search Console: verify (DNS TXT), submit sitemap; Bing Webmaster Tools (import)
8	GA4 receiving visits
9	Google Business Profile website link points to the new domain
10	Domain auto-renew on; 2FA on hosting, domain and Git accounts

11. Testing after every deploy

- Automatic: `npm run check:seo -- https://<live-domain>` (add `OLD_DOMAINS=old.com` if there was one).
- Manual, owner-friendly: `docs/templates/testing-guide-template.md` (quick check after each update, Google searches for the tracked keywords, Rich Results Test, Schema Markup Validator, PageSpeed Insights, security header checker, Search Console, AI prompts, Google Business Profile).

12. Monthly routine and reporting

Every month	Who
Re-run the audit on the live site; save `audits/audit-YYYY-MM-DD.md` + PDF; compare score, fixed / still open / new	SEO owner
Search Console: indexing, Core Web Vitals, queries, clicks, positions for the 12 tracked keywords	SEO owner (with access)
AI test prompts in ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Claude, Google AI Overviews; record in HANDOFF.md	SEO owner
`npm audit` ; SSL and domain expiry	SEO owner

Every month	Who
2–4 new FAQs or articles from real customer questions; refresh hours, offers, photos	Owner + SEO owner
GBP: 4 posts, reply to reviews, check details	Owner

Progress report structure: at a glance → score before/now by section → what we did and what it means → what is working well → Lighthouse before/now → still open by owner → needs from the owner → next month → appendix with every issue then/now (template in `docs/templates/`).

13. Who does what

Owner	Scope
SEO owner (developer)	SEO, AEO, structured data, metadata, sitemap/robots, Search Console, analytics, dependencies, security headers, domain renewal, monthly audit
Designer / UI team	Design system, contact form styling and connection test, images and speed (P-series), all UI/UX items (U-series)
Business owner	Account access (Search Console, GBP, Analytics, hosting), facts, photos, approvals, compliance decisions

Write a separate brief for the designer with: ground rules (what not to break), tasks in priority order with "done when", Lighthouse targets, colour values, what the owner must supply, hand-over checklist.

14. Lessons learned (do not repeat)

What happened	Rule now
The site told Google its home was an old, broken domain (hard-coded in 12 files)	One `SITE_URL`; `OLD_DOMAINS` check
`/about` and `/about/` both worked; repo and live differed in slash form	Decide the slash form before launch; `trailingSlash: true`
Pages set their own `openGraph` and silently lost the layout's image and site name	Always `pageMetadata()`
Stat counters were `<h1>` and showed "0" before scrolling	Counters are `<p>` with the real number in the HTML
The location keyword was added 77 times in one pass; the owner called it a mess	Location at most once per visible page; show wording for approval first
Long dashes in new copy read as machine-written	No long dashes in website copy
Netlify `[[headers]]` did not reach pages served by the Next.js runtime	Headers in `next.config.js` and `netlify.toml`
The contact form showed "Message Received!" while nothing was delivered	Netlify Forms via `public/__forms.html`, success only on `response.ok`, real test before launch
Netlify blocked builds: "unrecognized Git contributor" (free plan, private repo)	Commit as the linked Git account; no co-author lines; link the account under Git contributors

What happened	Rule now
Camera photos of 4–12 MB made the home page 12 MB	Photo rules (≤ 200 KB, WebP/AVIF, `next/image`)
Dev server screenshots showed wrong fonts and animation states	Screenshots and reviews from the production server
A regulator advisory on healthcare advertising arrived mid-project	Check the industry's advertising rules before writing copy; record them in CLAUDE.md
Experience was given as two numbers (clinic years, teaching years)	Never add numbers together; state facts exactly as given

15. Client document rules

- Plain language. **Index first**, then what we fix, the outcome for the client and how they can check it. Technical detail goes in appendices.
- **No branch names, code details, file paths or repository links** in client documents.
- Every claim verified; otherwise "Not verified".
- Show the before/after for every change the client can see; get approval before publishing visible wording.
- One document index (`DOCUMENTS.md` in the project) listing every client and internal document with version and date.